

The King's Eyes - *Dylan Fisk*

On the sixth consecutive hour of practicing chess alone in my bedroom, my bloodshot eyes struggle to hold themselves open. My eyes ache as they strain to stare at my tiny monitor, but I can't stop yet. I need to practice because I need to win.

In two days, the rest of my life will be decided. This single match will be my final chance to make a name for myself. To prove that the life I seek is more than just some unreachable dream, that I can be someone, that these past eight years meant something, that my future can be sustained by wooden pieces and unrivaled intellect. To make this passion my reality, I will not lose.

From behind my monitor, the sunlight peaks through my small bedroom window, getting dimmer as it shifts into a warm orange hue. I've always loved the way the golden rays paint the back wall, striking my desk and bookshelves and projecting a shadow in the rough shape of a crown. But tonight, the darkness grows deeper and is a painful reminder of what little time I have left. Against the darkness, the brightness of my screen becomes even harder to bear.

In the midst of my intense focus, *pawn e4, knight f3*, a pulsing white light flashes across my screen. I turn around to see what on earth could be so bright at this dark hour.

What it is I cannot tell, but I fear it is not from this earth. The sun, maybe, or a fallen star, so utterly radiant that if there is anything within this cloud of pure light, it is lost to me. I remember learning that hallucinations can be the result of sleep deprivation. Is it one of those? It must be. As hard as it is to stop practicing, I really should get some rest. How do I expect to retain anything at the point of hallucination?

As I push myself up from the office chair I had started sinking into, a voice cuts through the light:

“Zachary, you know who I am, yet you continue to pretend you do not, seeking solace in ignorance, placing hope in victory. That shall continue no longer. Now go: find a new path in the darkness.”

His words are thunderous, commanding, and these accusations hit me with a force I had never felt before. For a moment, a part of me seems convinced by his words; a part of me recognizes the comforting undertone in his forceful voice, but I can’t confront it. I’m not ready to unravel like that.

I prepare to give an answer but as my tongue begins to form the first word, the bright light vanishes. No, wait. Not just the bright light, but *everything* disappears in an instant. The small wooden desk with its heavy chess books; the dim monitor and its painful glow; the overflowing backpack and its overdue assignments; the unmade bed with its scattered blankets and undone sheets; the setting sun through my bedroom window; gone, all gone!

Then, it hits me. “Find a new path in the darkness.” It was him. It had to be him, the mysterious sun with his patronizing words, who had struck me entirely blind!

My body suddenly jolts forward, and before I’ve had a chance to think, my fist is careening in the direction that the light was, my entire weight behind it. I feel my hand soar through the air to no avail and my body crashes into the floor. I had missed him. Is he gone? Intangible? I need to know. I want to strangle him.

But after standing there for ten minutes feeling around the room for him, I realize there’s no point in trying, so I stumble my way over to my bed and plop myself down. The memory foam padding that I feel along my back helps to ground me, so I’m no longer floating in space.

In this grounded state, I take a deep breath and attempt to rationalize. My first instinct is not to lose myself in the how or the why, or to look much further than what is here and now, but

to face the more urgent question: what am I going to do about the match? Can I get them to postpone it? No, they'd simply have me forfeit. I could play chess blind by calling out the moves, but I'd have to know where the pieces are, and the further the match progresses, the harder it would be to keep track of everything. Not only that, but I'd have to have some sort of concept of where my opponent's pieces are and what he could possibly intend to do with them. On my own, there's simply no way I can pull that off. But I must, damnit, I must.

Then, I hear a familiar voice from outside the door. It is my mom's voice, calling out in her routine, sing-songy way:

"Zachary, it's time for dinner! Come get it before it's cold~"

Oh crap, dinner already? What the hell am I gonna tell her as I stumble my way down the stairs and into the kitchen with my eyes closed? I can't hide it, and I can't tell her I blinded myself or she'll rush me to the ER and then I *really* won't make it to my match. Do I tell her it was something supernatural? I'm not worried that she won't believe me. I'm worried that she will, and yet another thing will reaffirm my parents' religious delusion. But at this point, it can't be helped.

"Just a sec, Mom!" I call back. There's no point in delaying it. I've just gotta face her head on.

I attempt to draw a map of the house in my mind, but with no real reference points outside of my bedroom, it comes out hazy, useless. After some hesitation and with a half-baked plan to trace the wall with my hand, I say goodbye to the safety of my bed, sidle along the wall and through the door until eventually the wall ends and the stairs begin. I don't trust the stairs, so I opt to slowly crawl down them on all fours.

After a minute that felt like ten, I clear the stairs and orient myself towards the kitchen. The delightful scent of garlic bread illuminates my path, and I manage to make it past the living room while only bumping the couch twice and the coffee table once.

“Zach, honey, are you alright?” my mom’s voice startles me, much louder and closer than I expected it to be. “I heard a lot of noises from the living room.”

“Yes Mom, I’m fine.”

Unfortunately, I’m a horrible liar, and my words do little to keep her from grabbing my face and tilting it up towards her own. Her breath is warm and far too garlicky for my nose to handle from this close.

“You certainly don’t look fine! Why are your eyes closed?” she asks.

“So... I was just in my—”

“What’s going on here?” a gruff voice cuts through my bumbling speech and causes my heart to jump. Dad must’ve heard Mom’s concern and came from the dining room to check on her. Either that or his nose led him to the same place mine did.

“Look at Zachary’s eyes, dear! There’s something going on with him!” Mom says.

After a brief moment of examination, Dad responds, “Yeah, they’re not looking too good. What the heck happened?” and the spotlight is back on me.

“I was just in my room practicing chess and some... bright light showed up and I heard it say something, and then everything went dark and now I—”

“A *light* spoke to you? Is this some kind of joke?” Dad cuts me off again, his tone sharp and unamused.

“It isn’t, I swear! I seriously can’t see! It had to be some kinda hallucination or something.”

“Hallucination? That sounds more like an *angel*, Zach. I remember Sydney from church mentioning a vision like this before. ” Mom says, and if I could, I’d roll my eyes at her ridiculous suggestion.

Dad’s booming laugh interrupts my incoming rebuttal. “Well how about that, Zach? Was it an angel you saw with those *rational* eyes of yours?”

“Sh-shut up! Please don’t make this any harder for me!” I respond, trying not to let his condescending laughter worm its way beneath my skin. I was hoping it would just be Mom’s delusional antics I’d have to endure, but of course Dad had to butt into this. He’s always on my case about this kind of stuff.

“Oh, leave him alone, George. I’m sure he’s just scared and confused, and for what it’s worth, I’m willing to believe him. I don’t think he’d joke about this,” Mom says to pacify my father’s aggression. I nod, thankful for her intercession.

“Okay, okay. Well, I’m starving, so why don’t we talk more about this over dinner, huh?” Dad says.

“That’s a great idea! You’ll eat with us, right Zach?” Mom says, inviting me to the last place I’d want to be tonight.

I usually take my food upstairs and eat it in my room so I can avoid whatever rituals and meaningless conversations occur over our “Christian” dinner table. But tonight, that doesn’t seem like much of an option.

“I’d love to,” I respond through gritted teeth.

“Oh, wonderful! I can’t remember the last time you joined us!” Mom exclaims.

After a brief pause filled with the clanking of dishes, she trusts a plate in my hand that I can only assume has my dinner on it. I feel her hand on my shoulder as she guides me over to the

dining room and sets me up at the table. I reach out into the void with my free hand until it makes contact with the flat tabletop and graciously lower the hefty porcelain plate onto it. Is this how a rook feels when I lift it up and slide it across the board?

Dad's heavy footsteps follow close behind, stopping abruptly while his plate clatters on the wooden table.

"Let me pray for us," his decisive tone denies any word of protest long before it climbs up to my lips. I wonder if he's staring at me as he begins: "Thank you Lord for this delicious food. May you bless it to our bodies and bless the beautiful hands that prepared it"—at this, Mom chuckles a little. I pretend to gag—"And thank you for having Zach eat with us tonight. We pray over the work you're doing in his life in Jesus' name. Amen."

"Amen," Mom echoes, and I wonder if that word has lost its meaning from her lifelong repetition of it.

"Well, Zach, I'm just thankful you were safe and sound at home when this happened," Mom says between mouthfuls. "For now, all we can do is pray that your sight comes back soon."

"But my match is in two days! What am I supposed to do if I still can't see by then?"

"Are you kidding me, Zach? You're blind and you might've seen an angel, and *that's* what you're worried about?" Dad blurts out, the baffled anger rising in his voice. I know this tone of his well. It's frequented my ears since that first time I told him I didn't believe, and has since come out at times when his indoctrinated mind can't fathom anything more real or more important than his invisible, intangible God.

"Yes, Dad, it is! If I don't win my match on Sunday, my chances of going pro are pretty much shot!"

“Well maybe then you’ll look up from your computer and think about something real for once!”

“George, please!” Mom jumps in to mediate again. “He’s only eighteen. Let the poor boy dream a little!”

“Thank you, Mom. Somehow, I have to find a way to win on Sunday,” I say. It’s all I know how to do, after all.

“Tch, fine,” Dad concedes, “but don’t expect me to be in the crowd.” His chair creaks as he sulks back into it, signaling his withdrawal from the conversation.

After a pause, Mom offers “Can you have someone else help you out?”

“Well, that’s what I was thinking, but I don’t know who to ask. Even if my friends would believe me—which they won’t—they’re all busy this weekend. And that just leaves you two, who don’t even know how the pieces move, nevermind how to call out the moves.”

She responds with another pause, showing the limits of her kindness.

“Wait, what about your brother? Doesn’t he know how to play chess?” she says with a light chuckle, and suddenly I wish that pause had lasted an eternity.

My brother? My backstabbing brother? Why would I ever ask *him* for anything? And besides, I don’t think we’ve had a civil conversation in at least a year. No way that’s gonna change now, and no way am I gonna come crawling to him for help! I don’t have a word to say to him until he finally apologizes for everything.

“Absolutely not,” are the only words I use to summarize the laundry list of reasons why I won’t be taking up Mom’s suggestion.

“Oh come on, Zachary! It breaks my heart knowing my two boys won’t even speak to each other! Can’t you just try to reconcile things with John?”

Now it's my turn to pause. I hate to hurt my mother's heart, but he owes me an apology with exponential interest and I refuse to swallow my pride. And yet, what other choice do I have? We didn't really play much growing up, and I don't remember him being particularly good at chess when we did, but if he at least knows what he's doing...

"Fine. I'll see if he can help me," I reply, each word more laborious than the next. "But don't think this means we'll be best friends again."

"I never asked you to be," she says, and I imagine a smug smile dancing across her lips. "John's at his church group tonight, so you can stop by his room when he gets home,"

"Of course he is," I mutter under my breath.

"You should really join him sometime! Our church has a big high school group so I'm sure you'd meet some good people," Mom adds unnecessarily.

"And maybe you could tell them all about your angel encounter, too," Dad throws in from the back of his chair.

"Whatever you say, Dad," I cough up to appease him.

I scarf down the rest of my meal as fast as I can, hoping to finish before John walks through the front door and my parents force the dreadful confrontation. If I have to talk to him, I want to do it on my own terms. Mom offers to walk me back up to my room but I decline, opting to awkwardly feel my way back to the stairs. I decide to crawl up them again and fumble my way through the second floor until I've found what seems like my room. I trace the outer wall until the familiar feeling of posters glide beneath my fingertips, confirming my assumption. With much relief, I locate my bed and throw myself onto it, relishing in the quiet air as I anxiously await John's return.

I'm imagining John sitting with a group of church boys in a circle on the floor, folding his hands and reciting Bible verses without meaning to an echo chamber when footsteps rattle up the stairs and a door clicks closed, snapping me back to reality.

It takes me a while to leave my bed, its soft sheets keeping me safe from the wretched task ahead. When I finally muster the courage, I inch over to my bedroom door with increased precision and make my way out into the hall again. I trace the wall, remembering the bumps and grooves from last time, and pause when my hand makes contact with a metal door knob. I can't tell if this is his room, so I press my ear to the door in hopes of confirming. The clicking of a mouse is the only reply, but that's all I need to know that he's in there. I make my hand into a fist and hover it inches from the door.

Summoning every ounce of strength I have, I move my fist to the door and am able to lightly tap it a few times. No response. I try again and with great effort I manage to make the sound a little bit louder. No response.

I bang the door with all my might.

"You can come in, Mom!" a voice calls from inside.

With one last deep breath, I twist the knob and slowly push open the door.

"What's up, Mo—oh... hey, Zach," his swivel chair creaks as he spins around to face me. I can feel the disappointment in his voice as he realizes I am not the comforting presence he anticipated.

"Hey John," I say to buy me time while I try to pick out the right words from the thousands that flood my brain. *You need his help, Zach. You need him.*

"So, uh, I know this is pretty sudden, and we haven't talked in a while, but, um... Tomorrow. You busy?"

“N-no, not really. Why?” his voice trembles a bit, and I wonder how well he remembers the last time we truly spoke. That’s when he told me he’d given in to religion, that he’d “heard something.” That’s when he shattered our pact, our loyalty to reason and to each other, our shield against my parents' religion. When he abandoned our friends because they weren’t “Christian,” abandoned *me*, made me an enemy in my home. Words weren’t enough for me back then.

“And what about Sunday?”

“Just church in the morning, but—”

“Oh great!” is all I can get out before I turn around to leave, but as I begin moving towards what I think is the door, *thunk!* My head collides with the wall. The pain radiates throughout the rest of my body and I can’t stop myself from crumbling to the ground.

“Whoa, Zach, are you good?” John says with feigned concern.

“Yup, I’m just fine, damnit,” I mumble as I slowly crawl back to my feet.

“What was that about? And what is *this* all about anyway? Why do you care if I’m free?”

“Well... look, I need your help. With chess. I have the most important match of my life on Sunday, but all of a sudden some stupid bright light thing showed up and made me blind, and now I have no shot at winning and if I don’t win—”

“Whoa whoa whoa. You got turned blind... by an *angel*?”

“Hey, shut up, this is serious! Look, I hate this, Mom already brought up the whole “angel” thing, I don’t want to talk about it, just... will you help me?” my desperate plea echoes around the room, underlying an anxious silence between us.

“Well, I see no reason why I should say yes,” he begins. “But if you’re telling the truth—and I have the feeling you wouldn’t lie about this—then God may be doing something in your life and I feel obligated to be a part of it.”

“The only thing God is doing in my life is *ruining* it!” I blurt out against my better judgment.

John lets out a loud, drawn out sigh. “Do you want my help or not?”

“Yes! Please! I need it!” I shout like my life depends on it, because it does.

“Okay fine,” he replies, to my half relief and half dread. “What exactly do you need *me* for?”

“You remember how to play chess?”

“Mhm.”

“Okay, then tomorrow, you help me practice and on Sunday, you accompany me to my match, make the moves that I call out, and tell me where my opponent’s pieces are if I ask.”

“Sounds easy enough,” he says with a smugness that pisses me off.

“Great. We start at seven AM tomorrow,” I say before I turn towards the door, this time with extreme caution.

“Seven AM?!” I hear him yell, but by this point, I’m already halfway out the door and I allow it to shut behind me. I don’t think it’s that unreasonable of a request. Perfection takes time, after all. But even so, it means I’ll have to spend the whole day with him. I’m already regretting this.

I feel my way over to my bedroom, taking comfort in the familiar layout of its walls and obstructions, and throw myself onto my bed. Once again, the softness of its padding below my disoriented body comforts me, and the darkness is no longer strange. It’s as if, for a moment, everything’s normal again, and my eyes are just taking a much-needed rest from the day’s stimulus. I’m not necessarily tired and I have no idea what time it is, but the normalcy and peace that envelops my body soon lulls me to sleep.

For the past week leading up to the match, I've been plagued by some sort of recurring nightmare. A battlefield, my kingdom under siege. Troops looked to their king for orders, orders caught in the throat of a leader drowning in his own pitiful indecision. Loyalty would bring my knights to the ends of lances. My bishops, rundown by the enemy's rooks, lay with their empty eyes heavenward, their prayers left unanswered. Even my queen, drawn to heroism by the desperate screams of her pawns, fell to these assailants. And just as my own neck met the blade and the crown slipped from my unworthy head, I awoke in the cold-sweat of a crumbled monarch. I had lost.

But tonight, the dream was different. A clearing deep in an evergreen forest, lit by the sparse moonbeams that made it through the branches. My arms outstretched, I was locked in combat, grappling. My adversary? That blinding light who had stripped me of all hope. Yet my sight in this dream world was unhindered, and in fact, immensely vivid. I could see past the cursing glow to the figure that stood within. I expected an angel; what I saw was a man. It was difficult to make much out about him, but I could tell he was strong—frustratingly strong—and somewhat beautiful.

As we continued to wrestle, it was clear that I was giving ground. My arms were beginning to fail as they met up against what seemed to be an unbreakable wall of raw strength. To give in to the one who stole my sight and left me with nothing but patronizing words... I couldn't fathom it. But at this point, my arms were quivering. I couldn't keep this up.

As if he perceived this doubt like a gap in my defense, the man suddenly pushed forward with an unstoppable might that my pitiful arms couldn't handle. In an instant, I was on the ground, pinned beneath his radiant strength. I had lost.

And yet, no blade met my neck. No crown clattered against the stone floor of a ruined fortress. Not a sound arose from that forest as we laid in the grassy clearing, my wrists secured by his hands, the galaxy in his eyes. I had lost and he had won, but I felt... free. It was as though his hands had taken the place of chains that once bound me.

“Seriously? You’re not even up yet?” John’s words wrest me from my deep slumber, from unconscious sight to conscious darkness.

“Seven AM. You said seven AM, and here you are, sleeping the day away!” His voice is loud and chaotic, discordantly jarring this early in the morning.

“Well, uh, I can’t really set my alarm like this, y’know.”

“Idiot! Well, it’s fine. You ready to get started?”

I feel his fingers brush against my open palm, attempting to take hold of it. I can’t stop myself from flinching, drawing my hand back from the sudden strangeness of the touch. His hand feels familiar, like one I had spent years high-fiving after completed levels or crude, well-timed jokes. Yet I hate these memories imprinted on his hand, and now, on mine.

He opts to grab my forearm this time, and before my body can again protest, he yanks me up and out of bed, out of my room, through the hall, and into his. This must really be what it’s like to be a pawn forcefully dragged into the fray.

“Why are we going to your room?” I ask.

“I already got everything set up,” he replies while he positions me carefully somewhere in his unfamiliar room. “Sit down.”

“You own a chess board?” I carefully lower myself to the floor. I reach forward and feel a few wooden pieces topple over in the wake of my curious hand.

“I bought it like a year ago. Figured it’d be nice to get the dust off of it.” he says, and I hear him place the disturbed pieces back into place. “Now, Mr. Professional, where do we begin?”

We start by seeing how well I can keep track of the board. John moves for both of us, calling out his own moves while I call out mine. But some of the moves he’s making are completely nonsensical. It seems he’s just a rookie after all. I shouldn’t have expected anything less—

“Rook a2, check.”

“What?” I ask, dumbfounded. “That can’t be right. What happened to my bishop on d2?”

“You moved that bishop to g5.”

“No, I moved my *other* bishop to b5, which was setting me up for—Damnit, John, are you screwing up my moves?”

“I was making the moves exactly as I heard them!”

“Well clearly, you weren’t listening! Whatever, let’s just start over.”

“Dude, I’m just trying to help. I’m sorry—”

“No, you’re not!” I blurt out without thinking, and the words settle like bricks between us. “You’re not sorry for anything!”

A deep, expectant sigh cuts the air. “I already told you: I have nothing to apologize for.”

“Nothing? Your betrayal of our pact is *nothing* to you? The friends you left behind are *nothing* to you?”

“We agreed to abide by the truth as we saw it with our own eyes. I didn’t break the pact when I decided to follow God.”

“Then your eyes deceived you.”

“Oh yeah? And how are those eyes working for you now, Zach?”

“Shut up.”

“No, you can’t avoid this! You know what you saw! You know why you can’t—”

“I said shut up!” my boiling blood rises to the surface, and I rise with it, no longer able to contain the burning rage. I prepare to strike him. I should’ve known it would end this way. Long gone are the days when we’d spend hours together playing games in my room, thankful we were close in age, thankful we were like-minded, thankful we had each other in this delusional household. This is just how it is now.

“Zach! Zach! Please, stop!” but John’s pleas only serve to betray his position. I carefully follow his desperate voice.

“But I have to win!” and my hand comes crashing down hard onto the carpet in front of me. The force of the punch radiates back into my arm, causing me to writhe, gripping my wrist.

“Why?”

This one word echoes around the silent room, fills my head and leaves like a wave crashing and receding again and again.

“‘Why?’ What a stupid question. I have to because...” but I can’t explain it. It’s something I just know, deep inside, as true as my own existence. “Well... if I don’t, I—”

“Are you afraid?”

“H-hell no. Why would you even ask me that?”

I hear his breath cut short and expect his reply, but he lets the air catch in his throat for a moment.

“Because...” but the answer doesn’t come. I wonder if he’s looking at me now as I grip the fist meant for his face, and if his anger’s holding back the words. But then, “Because *I* was afraid. Afraid I’d be wrong. Afraid I’d lose myself. Afraid I’d lose you.”

There’s a softness in his voice. It is new, or at least a bit dusty, and it catches me off guard. He’s never mentioned this before, although I suppose I hadn’t given him many chances to.

“But... if you were so afraid, why did you give in to it?” I couldn’t wrap my head around it.

“Don’t get me wrong: I tried to fight it. But it felt like I was fighting my own mind, and it was... exhausting. I had heard Him speak to me, heard the words Mom and Dad never stopped shoving down our ears but in *His* voice, and I couldn’t deny it no matter how much it hurt. ‘The man whose eyes never change his mind is—’

“—A madman.” I instinctively finish the quote. I’m surprised he even remembered it. We had come up with it around the same time we made the pact. I never thought he would dare try to use it against me.

“And when I finally did give in, I hadn’t lost myself as I had feared. I was different, sure, but I was far from gone. The only thing I had lost, it turns out, was you.”

“But then, why are you so different than you used to be? I miss the old you. Before I was just some ignorant sinner in your pious eyes.” Memories flash before me like a slideshow projected on the inside of my eyelids. A tear threatens to fall, but I quickly wipe it away.

John lets out a deep sigh. “I wish you wouldn’t say things like that. You’re still my brother, and sometimes I also find myself missing who I was before. But I don’t regret giving in to the truth. That’s how I continue to honor our pact. And if you’re honest with yourself, you’ll do the same.”

I take a moment to let his words simmer and to piece together the puzzle that is my infuriatingly confusing brother. I see what he's trying to do and I hate it, yet I can't seem to refute it. His words are too organic, desperate, vulnerable, and I hate that even more. Why can't he just let me hate him?

"I... I'm not convinced yet. Let's just get back to practicing. We've wasted way too much time."

Not a single unnecessary word passes between us for the hours we practice, just what I had hoped for. But strangely, the air seems a bit lighter, less oppressive, somewhere between discomfort and familiarity. It no longer feels like I'm in some stranger's company, hearing chess moves like a foreign language in some voice they didn't belong in. It feels natural, and by the end of our practice, I can tell we've both gotten much more comfortable in our roles.

After wrapping up our last match, John walks me back to my room and sets me down on the bed. I still don't like being helpless before him, but I can't say I would rather feel my way through the hallway again.

"So, you feeling good about tomorrow?" I hear John say from above me.

"I'm definitely feeling *better* about it. It's good to know I can beat a novice with my eyes closed."

"Well *sorry* I don't sit around and play chess all day! And I was just trying to help you out, y'know? I wasn't thinking too hard."

"Oh, *sure*."

"I'm serio—"

"Anyway, we leave for the match at 1:00 tomorrow, and you better not forget it!"

“I won’t, I won’t,” John says as the sound of his footsteps dampens in their approach to the door. But suddenly, the footsteps stop. “Hey, uh, church starts at 10:00 tomorrow if you wanted to—”

“Don’t push your luck,” I shoot back at his preposterous offer.

“Whatever,” he says, and I hear the door creak as he begins to close it.

“Wait! John!” I call right before the door finishes closing. The rush of air fills my ears as he throws the door back open.

“What’s up?”

“Thank you.”

Without a reply, he quickly shuts the door again. As I lay down and prepare myself to sleep, I wonder if he smiled at my gratitude.

John’s words permeate my mind through the night, piercing even my dreams. Distracted by these confusing revelations, I put up even less of a fight against the glowing man than I did the night before. I want to be frustrated that I’ve lost again, frustrated that this ‘angel’ has wormed its way into my dreams and is here to stay. But the relief my body feels lying there on the grass, no longer striving against this impossible foe, is overwhelming, and that frustration becomes impossible to act on. For the moment, I forget that I had lost entirely.

Match day is finally here, and the miniscule hope of my sight returning beforehand is officially gone. I’ll have to win it blind.

John drives me to the venue. The rest of the tournament had taken place at the library in the close-quarters basement reserved for tabletop events. This final match, however, would be

played in the town's community center in front of an audience. Just what I needed: more eyes to watch me fumble my way through the dark. I wonder what the scouts will think when they see one of the finalists escorted to his place by some seventeen year old kid. It doesn't matter. The only thing they care about is whether or not "checkmate" leaves my mouth or my opponents.

We share a few words on the way, but most of the ride is silent besides the rushing wind of passing cars. John tries to put on some music, but the lyrics distract me from the chess matches running through my head, so I yell at him until he turns it off. It's a relatively short trip, giving me little time to prepare and little time to deal with his antics.

When we reach the community center, John leads me by the hand through a set of automatic doors and past a group of gossiping strangers until we stop in front of what I can only assume is the front desk. After some negotiating with the receptionist regarding my condition, she grants me the accommodation of having John make my moves and ushers us to some backroom to prepare.

"I didn't know you were such a smooth talker, John." I say when we're alone again.

"Well, you *are* blind, and she didn't really seem interested in the full story, so it wasn't much lying on my part."

A small chuckle slips through my clenched teeth. "You ready for this?"

"I should be asking *you* that. But yes, I think so."

"Good. Just remember what we did yesterday and we shouldn't have any problems."

"You really think so? You're not nervous or anything?"

"Shut up," I say as I swallow the rising butterflies back into their cocoons. "No point in thinking about it now. I can't afford to lose."

"If you say so."

I hear some footsteps approach us, and then the words: “You guys are on in one minute.” I take one last deep breath. John places a hand on my shoulder and I wonder what he’s doing, but at this point, I don’t mind. And then, as at some mysterious visual cue I’m unaware of, he leads me out of the room.

As we make our way to the table, the air is still and tense. Somehow, I can feel the many eyes like a weight piling onto my chest. John must feel it too: his hand shakes gently on my shoulder until we reach some kind of foldable wooden chair.

“Good luck,” he whispers before setting me down in the chair and turning me towards the invisible board and my faceless opponent.

Instinctively, I shoot my hand out in front of me and shake the hand of the man on the other side of the table. I try to remember anything about him: his name, what he looks like, his rating. But every detail of the man escapes me, and the only image I can conjure is that of a wicked king with a cocky smirk plastered on his face, seated across the table. I might hear his name if I listen to the commencement of the match, but I’ve already entered deep into my mind palace where the arbiter’s words cannot reach me. I reach for the top of my head and adjust the crown that sits atop it.

I won’t let this castle crumble. I won’t let this crown fall.

The match begins like any other: *pawn e4, knight f3* and I follow along. In a way, it’s relieving to be playing the black pieces and letting him lead the way. But soon, my relief turns to confusion as he makes a strange variation to the game I’m familiar with. I don’t understand what he could possibly be doing. Is he trying to bait me into sacrificing a piece? Is he just trying to throw me off, taking advantage of my blindness? These thoughts swirl in an endless stream of possibilities and outcomes. I’m spiraling.

And then, I'm in the nightmare again. The wooden pieces' shuffling, the ever-present timer's ticking are drowned out by the clashing of steel, the toppling of stone, the groaning of war. My pawns and knights rush forward into combat without fear. I try to join them on the front lines but I freeze as I see my bleeding bishops retreat to await death within the castle walls. I... can't do it. I take a rook with me and climb back into my throne room, leaving my queen behind to live or die beside her loyal subjects. I know I'm a coward. That should have been me leading them into battle, but I *can't* lose this crown, no matter what.

"Kingside castle," I say. John's sharp breath betrays his concern, but he makes the move without any protest.

I watch from above as my queen fights desperately to protect me, but she is soon pinched and cut down by the enemy's merciless rooks. They're coming for me next. With their bloodied blades they're coming to take my head and my crown and my kingdom and my future and I won't even be able to see it come crumbling down. But damnit, I can't lose! I can't—

Why?

This one word breaks into my spiraling consciousness. John's stupid question, but no, it isn't his voice. It's the voice of the man in the light; powerful, yet soft. Suddenly, a bright flash appears in the dark void in front of me. I look up to where my enemy would be seated across the table, but the wicked king is gone. In his place is that man from the dream, looking at me with the same galactic eyes and making each move with the same strong hands.

He is winning and I am losing, but something is different. I can't see the palace or feel the blade anymore. I can only see the grassy clearing, can only feel his hands grip my wrists as he holds me in surrender, and I'm... relieved.

With one confident move, he positions his queen to place my king in check. I still have a few options to escape, though it's not looking good. But then, he extends his hand towards me, as if to say, *Are you ready to accept defeat and start again?*

I feel my hand begin to rise, but I hesitate. I am afraid to lose this match. Afraid to lose this chance at a future proving my worth the only way I know how. I'm not good at school and I hate the paths that lie beyond it. But maybe, maybe, there's another way.

With one deep breath, I extend my hand towards my opponent.

"I concede."

John gasps. My opponent takes my hand and says, "Good game." Applause from all around us fills the silence and washes away the lingering tension. I feel the adrenaline slowly fade as John leads me out of the venue and away from the board, the audience, the scouts, my future.

"You really conceded, huh?" he asks as he helps me into the car.

"Yup, I really did."

"I'm sorry, bro. I know how much you wanted to win that match."

I pause for a moment, thinking everything over. "Honestly, I'm okay."

As soon as the last word leaves my mouth, something like scales fall away from my eyes. Light floods through the slits in my eyelids and wipes away the darkness before me. The light is so powerful that I can't stop blinking and rubbing my eyes until things start fading into view.

"Zach, you alright?"

"I can see! I can finally see!" I shout. I turn to look at John. He seems older than I remember.

"For real? That's amazing! Praise God! He's got some pretty crazy timing, huh?"

I can't stop myself from laughing in response.

"Hey John. You wanna play a match when we get back?" I'm surprised to hear myself say.

A smile lights up his face. "Absolutely! But I won't be holding back this time!"

"Good," I say with a smile of my own as we drive home, my eyes fixed on the sun and its blinding light.